



SEMICOLONS

Joining two closely connected ideas

1 What is it?

Semicolons (SEM-ee-koh-lonz)

A semicolon (;) is a punctuation mark used to join two independent clauses — sections that could each be a complete sentence on their own — that are closely connected in meaning.

complete sentence + ; + closely related complete sentence

2 See it in action

Connecting ideas

"Sandip spent three hours in the library; he couldn't find the book he wanted."

Conjunctive adverb

"Sandip spent three hours in the library; however, he couldn't find the book."

Contrast

"It was the best of times; it was the worst of times."

Complex list

"I packed sunglasses, sun cream and a towel; a book and snacks; and my passport."



Look here!

Try the balancing-scales test: if both sides of your semicolon could each be their own complete sentence, you've used it correctly.

3 More to know

Rewritten

"Hayley loves sports; her favourite is basketball."

Rewritten

"Imogen missed the bus; she had to walk to town."

FUN FACT

The semicolon is a relatively young punctuation mark — it was introduced in Venice in 1494, which makes it practically a baby compared to the full stop, which dates back to the 3rd century BC.

4 Why it's used

Semicolons help: let a writer join two closely linked full sentences more tightly than a full stop would, without needing a conjunction like 'and' or 'but' — it shows the ideas belong together.

A semicolon can also tidy up a complicated list — when the items themselves contain commas, semicolons separate the groups clearly so the reader doesn't get lost.



Good spot!

A semicolon before words like however or therefore always needs a comma straight after that word.

5 Where you'll spot it

Joining two sentences

Two complete sentences joined with a semicolon instead of a full stop or conjunction, because they're closely related.

Before a conjunctive adverb

A semicolon before words like however, therefore, meanwhile or consequently, which is then followed by a comma.

⚠ Watch out!

Both sides of a semicolon must be a complete sentence on their own — think of it like balancing scales. "As the weather gets colder; I like to put more food out for the birds" is incorrect because "As the weather gets colder" isn't a complete sentence — that needs a comma instead.

6 Quick recap

Joins two complete sentences

Ideas must be closely linked

Can tidy up a complex list



Quick reminder!

If you're not sure whether to use a semicolon, a full stop will almost always work too — the semicolon just shows the ideas are more tightly connected.